
Does Statutory Structure Help? Retrieving Every Indispensable Provision for Sri Lankan Conveyancing Scenarios

Himath Dhanapala, Lahiru Dilshan, Praveen de Silva, Nisansa de Silva
Dept. of Computer Science & Engineering, University of Moratuwa, Sri Lanka
{himathd.23, lahirud.23, praveend.23, nisansadds}@cse.mrt.ac.lk

Abstract

A conveyancing question is answered only when every provision it turns on is in hand: the operative rule, the definition it relies on and the exception that decides the case. We ask whether structure-aware retrieval finds these complete sets better than flat retrieval does, in Sri Lanka, where prior work is scored on questions generated from the Act text. We build a corpus of 52 principal enactments and 60 amending Acts (4,557 sections, 6,346 typed edges for definitions, exceptions, qualifications, cross-references and amendments); a benchmark of 50 questions in 40 fact patterns from Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing examinations, each mapped to the sections indispensable to a complete answer with verbatim provenance; and seven retrievers, from BM25 to a hierarchical system that routes to Acts, retrieves seed sections and expands them along the typed edges. The principal metric, complete-indispensable recall, credits a question only when every indispensable section is retrieved. Against proposed labels, this explicit graph shows no complete-recall gain at 20 on the test split: 0.344 for hybrid BM25 and dense fusion versus 0.312 for the structure-aware retriever; the paired matter-level bootstrap interval includes zero. No system completes a question needing four or more sections, and only two of the sections the structure-aware retriever missed were reachable by any typed edge from a retrieved seed: most proposed dependencies lack an explicit edge from a seed. The agent-produced labels are released on [Hugging Face](#) as provisional reference labels and await three-attorney validation (Appendix B).

1 Introduction

Whether a Sri Lankan notary may attest a deed outside the notary’s judicial zone turns on several provisions at once: the rule limiting territorial authority, the provision allocating responsibility when two notaries participate, and the Prevention of Frauds Ordinance provision governing the validity of notarial execution. Retrieving one or two of them yields an answer that looks grounded and is legally incomplete, so statutory retrieval should be judged on whether it returns the complete bundle a question needs.

Legal retrieval benchmarks have mostly scored cases or passages independently [Paul et al., 2025, Pipitone and Alami, 2024]. Statute-oriented resources now pose scenario questions whose facts share little vocabulary with the controlling text [Zheng et al., 2025]: KoBLEX contains provision-grounded multi-hop questions [Lee et al., 2025], GreekBarRetrieval pairs bar-examination questions with the articles in official solutions [Beta et al., 2026], and others study structure-aware [Chae et al., 2026] and temporally sensitive [Prior et al., 2026] statutory retrieval. None jointly separates indispensable from supporting provisions, scores with an all-or-nothing bundle measure, and tests through matched ablations whether typed statutory relationships help. For Sri Lanka, LawChain retrieves over Acts with BM25, dense embeddings and a Neo4j graph [Atukorala et al., 2026], but its questions are

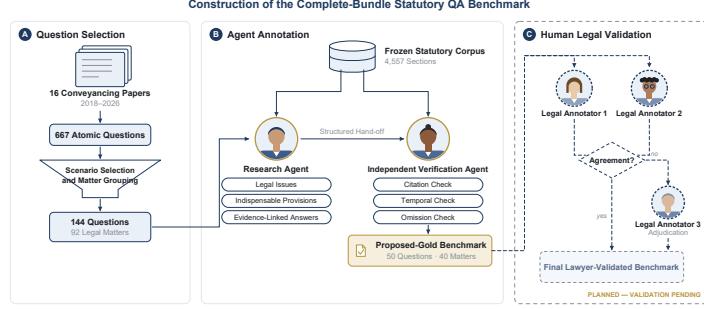


Figure 1: Benchmark construction. Automated stages (solid) are complete; the three-rater legal validation (dashed) is planned and pending.

generated from the legislative text, judged by Gemini, and need one provision each; Athulathmudali [2025] retrieve over scenario records rather than sections; ScaLe-QA [Jayawardena et al., 2024] trains embeddings on judgments without a section-level benchmark.

We ask: does structure-aware retrieval improve recall of every legally indispensable provision for scenario questions in a low-resource jurisdiction? We contribute (1) an expert-informed corpus of Sri Lankan conveyancing and notarial legislation linking enactments, sections, amending Acts and typed relationships; (2) a benchmark from sixteen Law College examination papers whose proposed labels separate indispensable, supporting and background provisions and tie answer claims to verbatim statutory text (§2); and (3) an evaluation of lexical, dense, hybrid, hierarchical and provision-bundle retrievers under complete-indispensable recall with matched ablations and matter-level uncertainty (§3, §4). The tested edge graph does not demonstrate a gain over strong hybrid retrieval: most missed indispensable sections lack a one-hop edge from retrieved seeds. Attorney validation has not run, so every number here is measured against agent-produced proposed labels (§5).

2 Corpus and benchmark

Corpus. The principal enactments are the 52 statutes named in the Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing course tables; we then collected their amending Acts (Appendix G). The corpus is built deterministically from structured JSON trees parsed from Government Printer and private-republisher PDFs and checked structurally, not legally: 52 consolidated principal enactments, 60 amending Acts kept as separate documents so amendment relationships have a source node, 4,557 sections (the retrieval and scoring unit) and 17,854 sub-section provisions. Six edge types (6,346 edges) are derived from the trees: cross-references are typed by the wording around them into `DEFINES`, `EXCEPTS`, `QUALIFIES`, `PROCEDURALLY_REQUIRES` or `CROSS_REFERENCES`; a section that uses a term defined in the same Act gets a `DEFINES` edge to the defining section (3,780 edges, the bulk of the graph); `AMENDS` edges link amending sections to the principal sections they change. Each section carries the year it came into force, which the temporal filter uses. The cue-word typing is a heuristic and is ablated (Appendix A).

Questions and annotation. We start from 667 atomic questions split out of sixteen Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing papers (2018 to 2026); 210 classified keep or enrich form the candidate pool. Questions sharing a fact pattern form a matter and are never split across agents, dataset splits or bootstrap samples. After quarantining 18 for background-boundary problems and sending 66 to manual review, Tier A holds 144 questions in 92 matters, each dated by its exam session so that “the law in force” is fixed. Each matter was researched by one agent (Claude Opus 5, tool access limited to a search interface over the frozen corpus) and checked by a second agent that had not seen the research (Figure 1). The researcher classifies the authority requirement (statute only, mixed, case only, unclear), records every provision with a verbatim excerpt that a validator checks against the corpus, labels it indispensable, supporting or background, counts legal hops, drafts an answer with per-claim provenance and, for enrich questions, adds labelled synthetic facts. The verifier re-reads every cited section, checks role, temporal applicability and omissions along the corpus edges, and marks it verified, partially verified, rejected or unresolved. A question enters the benchmark

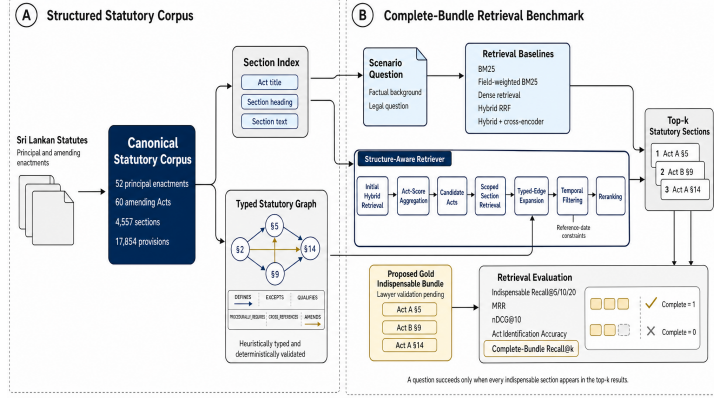


Figure 2: (A) The corpus yields a section index and a typed statutory graph. (B) A scenario question is answered by five flat baselines and by the structure-aware retriever; the top- k sections are scored against the proposed gold bundle, and a question counts only when every indispensable section is retrieved.

only if it is statute-only, every indispensable provision is verified or partially verified, and the map validates: 50 questions in 40 matters, 23 statutes, 84 distinct indispensable sections, 17 questions spanning more than one Act, 31 needing three or more sections (funnel in Appendix B; one record in Appendix C). Questions needing case law are reserved, not forced into a statute-only answer. The split is by matter: development 8 matters (10 questions), test 32 (40). Agent agreement is not legal validation, so the gold is labelled proposed: three attorneys-at-law will rate independently from the shipped review packets, with two-of-three agreement on every indispensable provision required for inclusion (Appendix B); no rating has been collected at the time of writing.

3 Retrieval systems

All systems take the same query, the normalised background (enriched where enrichment applied) followed by the question, and return sections (Figure 2; settings in Appendix D). S1 is BM25 over title, heading and body [Robertson and Zaragoza, 2009]. S2 is field-weighted BM25 over Act title, part heading, section heading, body, defined terms and cross-reference text. S3 is dense retrieval with bge-base-en-v1.5 [Xiao et al., 2024], scoring long sections by the maximum over overlapping windows. S4 fuses S2 and S3 by reciprocal rank fusion [Cormack et al., 2009]. S5 reranks the top 100 of S4 with the MS MARCO MiniLM cross-encoder [Wang et al., 2020, Reimers and Gurevych, 2019]. S6 follows the document-then-passage structure of HiREC [Choe et al., 2025]: Acts are scored by the sum of their top five fused section scores (amending Acts fold into their principal), the top 3 Acts are kept, and hybrid retrieval is rerun inside them. S7, the structure-aware retriever, takes the top 15 routed sections as seeds, adds every target of an enabled typed edge to the pool with support accumulating over seeds, drops sections not in force at the matter’s reference date, reranks with the same cross-encoder, and scores by the average of the normalised reranker and fused scores plus $\gamma \log(1 + \text{support})$, $\gamma = 0.15$. Everything except the reranker and the embedding model is deterministic, and each component is switched off in turn.

4 Results

Metrics. Indispensable recall at k ($R@k$) is the share of a question’s indispensable sections in the top k . Complete-indispensable recall ($C@k$), the principal metric, is 1 only when all of them are retrieved, the set-level exact match of KoBLEX [Lee et al., 2025] at a cutoff. We also report MRR of the first indispensable section, nDCG@10 (gain 2 indispensable, 1 supporting) and Act identification accuracy at 10. Questions from one matter are averaged first; means and 95% intervals are matter-level bootstraps (2,000 resamples) and comparisons are paired. Hyperparameters were chosen on the development split; Table 1 is the test split.

Table 1: Test split (40 questions, 32 matters), matter-macro means. R = indispensable recall, C = complete-indispensable recall, Act = Act identification accuracy. Bootstrap intervals in Appendix F.

System	R@10	R@20	C@10	C@20	MRR	nDCG@10	Act@10
BM25	0.452	0.491	0.250	0.281	0.503	0.345	0.719
Field-weighted BM25	0.456	0.482	0.250	0.281	0.540	0.361	0.672
Dense (bge-base)	0.282	0.379	0.125	0.188	0.316	0.186	0.562
BM25F + dense (RRF)	0.454	0.546	0.266	0.344	0.543	0.372	0.625
Hybrid + cross-encoder	0.250	0.413	0.125	0.234	0.223	0.185	0.562
Hierarchical Act→section	0.447	0.496	0.297	0.375	0.509	0.357	0.469
Hierarchical + bundle (ours)	0.454	0.480	0.281	0.312	0.495	0.334	0.469

Main result. Fusing field-weighted BM25 with dense retrieval (S4) is the strongest system on R@20 (0.546) and on Act identification; C@20 differences among S4, S6 and S7 are uncertain: S6 reaches C@20 of 0.375 and S7 0.312, against 0.344 for S4, and every pairwise difference among S4, S6 and S7 has a bootstrap interval that includes zero (Appendix F). In this test, two components hurt. The MS MARCO cross-encoder (S5) drops MRR from 0.543 to 0.223 and C@10 to 0.125. Act routing with three retained Acts contains every gold Act on only 44% of test questions (12 of 40 need two or more Acts), so Act identification falls from 0.625 (S4) to 0.469 (S6, S7), while correctly routed questions are retrieved more completely, which is why C@20 holds. Dense retrieval alone is weak (C@20 0.188) but lifts BM25 in fusion (R@20 from 0.482 to 0.546). None of this is comparable with LawChain’s recall at 5 of 0.94 [Atukorala et al., 2026], which asks only whether the one source Act of a generated question is in the top five.

Ablations and errors. Removing typed expansion, the dense channel, amendment edges or the reranker from S7 each lowers C@20 by one question in 32 matters; removing definition, exception or cross-reference edges individually changes nothing; removing the temporal filter gains one question whose gold is a 2022 amending section that recites superseded wording (Appendix E). No difference is separable from zero. Across systems C@20 is 0.33 to 1.0 on the three test questions with one indispensable section, 0.25 to 0.67 on the twelve with two, 0.2 to 0.4 on the five with three, and 0.0 on all twenty with four or more. Of the 114 indispensable sections S7 left outside its top 20, two were reachable by a single typed edge from any retrieved seed: the graph is dominated by term-matching definition edges (3,780 of 6,346); most proposed-gold dependencies lack a one-edge path from retrieved seeds. Enriched scenarios, whose added facts name the conditions the provisions test, are easier than the originals (C@20 0.43 against 0.11 for S7).

5 Limitations

The labels are proposed, not attorney-validated. Legal review may add, remove or relabel indispensable provisions, changing recall values and possibly system rankings. Only statute-only questions with governing text in the frozen corpus are scored: 36 Tier A questions lack governing text or doctrine, and 38 questions need case law. The test has 40 questions in 32 matters, so intervals are wide. Edge typing uses cue words and temporal filtering uses insertion years rather than version histories; richer relations and legal-domain rerankers are untested. Answer generation is not scored, and retrieved statutory text still requires lawyer review.

6 Conclusion and future work

Against proposed labels on 40 test questions, the tested Act routing and explicit-edge expansion do not demonstrate a complete-recall gain over hybrid BM25 and dense fusion. No system completes a question needing four or more sections. The one-hop graph leaves most jointly required provisions unreachable; richer legal relations remain untested. Future work starts with three-attorney validation (Appendix B) and release of validated gold with agreement statistics, so every result can be re-measured against lawyer-approved labels. Other steps are domain adaptation of the dense retriever and cross-encoder, and a wider benchmark covering reserved case-law questions, more matters and Acts.

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A Corpus construction

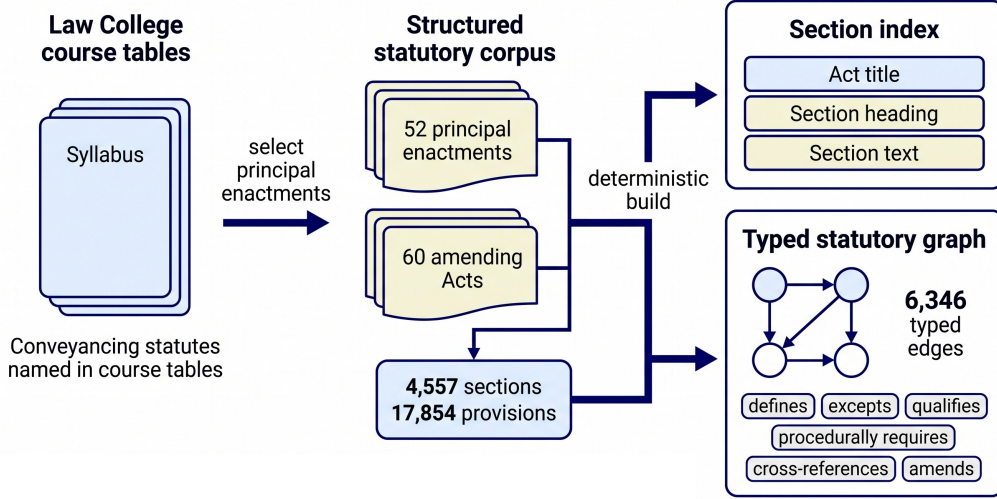


Figure 3: Syllabus-guided corpus construction. Law College conveyancing course tables identify the principal enactments; amending Acts remain separate source documents. A deterministic build yields the section index and a heuristically typed statutory graph. The graph is structurally checked, not lawyer-validated for legal indispensability.

Cross-references are typed by the wording around them: “within the meaning of” becomes `DEFINES`, “notwithstanding” and “shall not apply” become `EXCEPTS` (106 edges), “subject to” becomes `QUALIFIES` (131), “in the manner prescribed” and “under section” become `PROCEDURALLY_REQUIRES` (1,153), and anything else stays `CROSS_REFERENCES` (847). Term-matching `DEFINES` edges number 3,780 and `AMENDS` edges 329; 954 sections have at least one amendment. 4,138 of the 4,557 sections belong to principal enactments; provisions are kept for display and gold excerpts. Each section carries the year it came into force (the Act’s year, or the inserting amendment’s). The corpus fingerprint is `f119236b806f`.

B Benchmark funnel and validation protocol

Table 2: Benchmark funnel and gold statistics. All gold is proposed and pending lawyer validation.

Funnel	questions	Gold set	
source atomic questions	667	questions / matters	50 / 40
keep or enrich candidates	210	enrich questions	25
Tier A (clean, confident)	144	statutes represented	23
annotated by agents	144	distinct indispensable sections	84
statute-only, proposed gold	50	hop count 1 / 2 / 3+	1 / 10 / 39
reserved (mixed or case law)	38	indispensable sections per question 1 / 2 / 3+	3 / 16 / 31
blocked (missing authority, ambiguity)	36	questions with >1 gold Act	17
eligible after verification	50	lawyer approved	0

Annotation checks. A deterministic validator (no LLM) checks every legal map against a JSON schema and the corpus: each cited section exists and its Act, number and title agree with the corpus row; each excerpt is a verbatim substring of the section body; indispensable, supporting and background sets are disjoint; a proposed-gold question has at least one indispensable provision, a hop count of at least one, and no case-law citation in its answer; enrich questions carry labelled synthetic facts and keep questions carry none. A verification report and a disagreement log are written per

matter. Review packets and empty approval forms are prepared locally for attorneys and excluded from the public benchmark release.

Data availability. The provisional benchmark and evaluation code are available from the public Hugging Face repository under tag v1.0-paper-provisional. Its address is:

<https://huggingface.co/datasets/lanka-legal-nlp/draftly-statutory-retrieval>

The release supports inspection and scoring predictions, but excludes the frozen Act text and retrieval systems needed to reproduce the paper’s runs.

Legal validation protocol. The validation follows the human stage of KoBLEX [Lee et al., 2025], adapted to the provision as the unit. Three raters, all attorneys-at-law, work independently from the review packets. For every indispensable provision they answer two questions: is this the correct authority for the claim it supports, and could the question be answered completely without it. For every question they answer three more: is the statute-only classification correct, is any indispensable provision missing, and how legally accurate is the draft answer on a five-point scale. A question enters the validated set only when at least two of three raters agree on every indispensable provision and on statute-only status; disagreements go to adjudication rather than to a silent majority. We will report raw agreement, Fleiss’ κ , and the number of agent-proposed provisions rejected, added or relabelled, which is itself a measurement of agent-produced legal gold.

C A benchmark question

One development-split question, rendered from the public-input and private-gold records. Test-split questions are not printed. Every gold element below is agent-produced and awaits the validation in Appendix B.

Public input. Question M027-Q01, paper 4, October 2024 sitting; reference date 2024-10; enrichment not applied.

Background. Kanthi Peiris is a Notary practicing in Colombo. Shantha Ratnayake is her brother-in-law and is the owner of an apartment in Negambo. Shantha wishes to lease out his apartment for 3 years at a monthly rental of Rs.120,000/= to one Ananda Gamage who is willing to take on lease in accordance with the said terms. However, Shantha who lives in Negambo is unable to come to Colombo to sign the Agreement.

Question. How can this Agreement be signed by both parties and what steps should Kanthi follow with regard to the registration of this Agreement?

Proposed gold (private view). Authority requirement STATUTE ONLY; legal hop count 4; gold Acts 1-1907, 23-1927, 7-1840; status PROPOSED GOLD, lawyer validation PENDING.

1. Whether a three-year lease of an apartment must be executed notariially, and in whose presence the lessor and lessee must sign.
2. How the agreement can be validly signed when the lessor cannot attend before the Colombo notary - execution before more than one notary at different times and places, or execution by a duly authorised attorney under a registered power of attorney.
3. What registration steps the notary must take for a lease of land situated in a district other than the one in which she resides and practises, and within what time.

Indispensable provision	Excerpt checked verbatim against the corpus
Prevention of Frauds Ordinance No. 7 of 1840, s. 2(1)(a)	shall be in force or avail in law unless - (a) the relevant deed or instrument shall be in writing, signed by every executant or by any person duly authorised by such executant and the witnesses in the presence of a lic. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (12)	(12) He shall not authenticate or attest any deed or instrument unless the person executing the same and the witnesses shall have signed the same in his presence and in the presence of one another, and unless he shall h. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (22)	(22) He shall not authenticate or attest any deed or instrument in any area other than that in which he is authorized to practice, nor in any language other than that in which he is authorized to practice nor authentica. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (25)	(25) Where any deed or instrument is executed or acknowledged before more than one notary- (a) the notary who first attests such deed or instrument shall comply with all the requirements of rule (20), and every other no. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 32(2)(i)	(2) In the case of any deed or instrument which is to be executed by two or more parties, both or all of whom, as the case may be, do not sign the deed or instrument at the same time and place- (i) the deed or instrumen. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (30A)	(30A) It shall be the duty of every notary to submit for registration to the Registrar, every deed or instrument attested by him before the expiry of thirty days from the date of attestation thereof: Provided that, wher. . .
Registration of Documents Ordinance No. 23 of 1927, s. 8(b)	(b) if executed or made after the commencement of this Ordinance, all instruments, including wills, decrees and orders of any court or authority, and awards, which purport or operate to create, confer, declare, limit, a. . .
Registration of Documents Ordinance No. 23 of 1927, s. 14(1)	(1) Every instrument presented for registration shall be registered in the book allotted to the division in which the land affected by the instrument is situated
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 2	Every appointment to the office of notary shall be by warrant granted by the Minister, and shall specify the area within which, and the language or languages in which, the person appointed is authorized to practice.

Supporting (not scored): 1-1907/s37, 23-1927/s26, 23-1927/s7, 4-1902/s2, 4-1902/s3, 4-1902/s3A, 4-1902/s3B.

Reasoning edges (source → target):

JOINTLY REQUIRED	7-1840/s2 → 1-1907/s31; 23-1927/s8 → 23-1927/s14
QUALIFIES	1-1907/s31 → 1-1907/s32; 23-1927/s8 → 23-1927/s7
PROCEDURALLY REQUIRES	7-1840/s2 → 1-1907/s31; 1-1907/s31 → 23-1927/s14
CROSS REFERENCES	1-1907/s31 → 4-1902/s2; 4-1902/s3A → 7-1840/s2
DEFINES	1-1907/s2 → 1-1907/s31

Draft answer (agent-written, unvalidated). *Issue.* How a three-year lease of a Negombo apartment at Rs.120,000 a month can be signed by a lessor who cannot come to Colombo and by a lessee who can, and what a Colombo notary must then do to register the instrument.

Rule. A lease of immovable property for a period exceeding one month is of no force in law unless it is in writing, signed by every executant, or by a person duly authorised by the executant, and by the witnesses in the presence of a licenced notary present at the same time and in the presence of one another, and attested by that notary (Prevention of Frauds Ordinance s.2(1)(a)). The notary may not attest unless the executant and the witnesses signed in her presence and in the presence of one another (Notaries Ordinance s.31 rule (12)), and she may not attest in any area other than the area in which she is authorised to practise (s.31 rule (22)). The Ordinance nevertheless contemplates a deed executed or acknowledged before more than one notary and divides the attestation duties between the first attesting notary and every other attesting notary (s.31 rule (25)), and s.32(2) provides for parties who do not sign at the same time and place, deeming the instrument executed for the purposes of rules (6), (7), (23) and (25) when it is first signed. Alternatively the lessor may authorise an attorney: a power of attorney executed in Sri Lanka must be executed before two witnesses and attested by a notary (Powers of Attorney Ordinance s.2), must meet the additional requirements of s.3A where the transaction falls within s.2 of the Prevention of Frauds Ordinance, must be submitted for registration with the Registrar-General within one month (s.3(1)(b)), and the attesting notary must check the Registrar-General's volumes and folios and state in her attestation that it has not been revoked (s.3B), keep a true copy with her protocol and forward a copy with the duplicate (Notaries Ordinance s.31 rule (30)), and take the attorney's affidavit that the power is genuine, in force and the grantor alive. As to registration, an instrument creating an interest in land is deemed to affect land and so is registrable (Registration of Documents Ordinance s.8(b)), an unregistered instrument is void against a subsequent duly registered instrument taken for value (s.7(1)), registration must be effected in the book allotted to the division in which the land is situated (s.14(1)), and the notary acting for a party may present it (s.26(1)(d)). The notary must submit the deed for registration within thirty days of attestation, or sixty days

where it is to be registered outside the jurisdiction in which she practises (Notaries Ordinance s.31 rule (30A)), send the duplicate and Form F1 list to the Registrar of Lands of her own district by the fifteenth of the following month (rule (26)), send a certified copy to the Registrar of Lands of the district where the land lies (rule (29)), and use due diligence in registering where she has instructions and funds (s.37).

Application. The lease is for three years, well outside the one-month exclusion, so notarial execution is compulsory and Shantha cannot simply sign at home and send the paper to Colombo. Kanthi practises in Colombo and the apartment and Shantha are in Negombo, so rule (22) prevents her attesting Shantha's signature outside the area she is authorised for. Two lawful routes remain. First, execution before more than one notary under rule (25): Ananda Gamage signs the agreement before Kanthi in Colombo with two witnesses, and Shantha signs the same instrument before a notary authorised to practise where he is, each notary attesting the signatures taken before her or him, each numbering the instrument in his or her own protocol register, and s.32(2) accommodating the fact that the parties sign at different times and places. Second, Shantha grants a power of attorney, attested by a notary before two witnesses and complying with s.3A because the lease falls within s.2 of the Prevention of Frauds Ordinance, registers it with the Registrar-General within one month, and his attorney then signs before Kanthi in Colombo along with Ananda; Kanthi must satisfy herself from the Registrar-General's volumes and folios that the power stands unrevoked and say so in her attestation, take the attorney's affidavit, and keep and forward copies of the power. Either way she must have an assurance that the stamp duty is provided before attesting. On registration, the lease creates an interest in land and is registrable; it must go to the land registry for the division in which the Negombo apartment is situated, not Colombo. Because that registration is outside the jurisdiction in which Kanthi practises, she has sixty days from attestation to submit it, she must transmit the duplicate and Form F1 list to the Registrar of Lands of her own district by the fifteenth of the following month, and she must send a certified copy to the Registrar of Lands of the district in which the apartment lies. If the apartment forms part of a registered Condominium Property, she should also check whether the interest has to be registered under the Registration of Title Act rather than in the ordinary land register. The scenario does not state Shantha's judicial zone, whether the apartment is registered condominium property, or whether the parties have instructed and funded Kanthi to register, so those points are stated conditionally.

Conclusion. The agreement can be signed either before two notaries at different times and places, Ananda before Kanthi in Colombo and Shantha before a notary where he is, or by an attorney holding a duly attested and registered power of attorney signing for Shantha before Kanthi. Kanthi must then have the duty stamped, submit the instrument for registration in the land registry division covering the Negombo apartment within sixty days of attestation, transmit the duplicate with the Form F1 list to the Registrar of Lands of her own district by the fifteenth of the following month, and send a certified copy to the Registrar of Lands of the district where the apartment is situated.

Claim-level provenance, first two of 16:

rule A lease of immovable property for a period exceeding one month is of no force in law unless it is in writing, signed by every executant or a person duly authorised by the executant and by the witnesses in the presence of a licenced notary, and attested by that notary. ← 7-1840/s2, 1-1907/s31, 7-1840/s2

rule A notary may not attest a deed unless the executant and the witnesses signed it in her presence and in the presence of one another. ← 1-1907/s31

D Configuration and compute

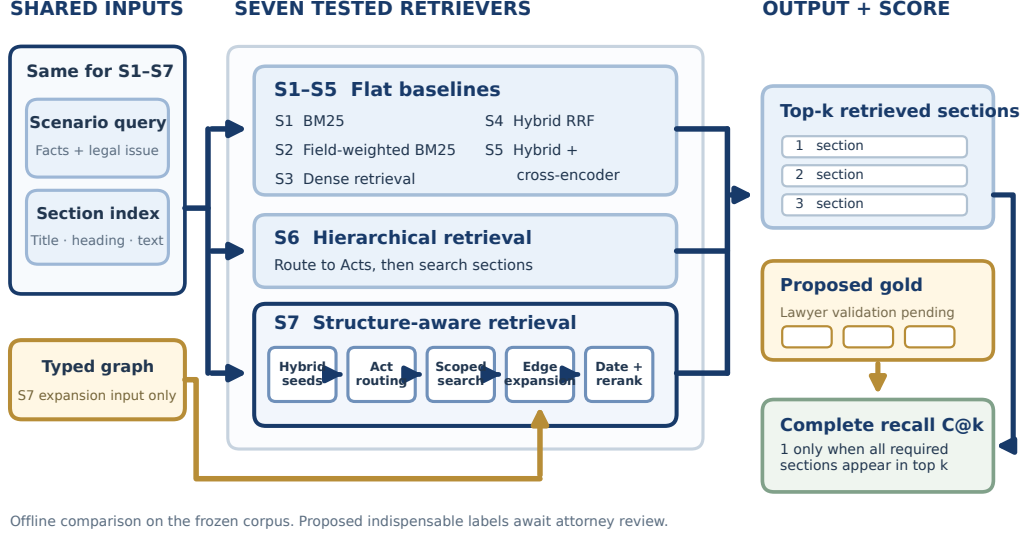


Figure 4: Offline retrieval and evaluation overview. S1–S5 are flat baselines; S6 routes the query to Acts before section retrieval; S7 adds typed-edge expansion and temporal filtering. The same scenario question and section index are used throughout, while typed graph edges enter S7’s expansion stage only. Returned top- k sections are compared with a proposed indispensable bundle, pending attorney validation.

All runs: corpus fingerprint f119236b806f, run main-test, git commit e491f2d26f, CPU only.

- BM25: $k_1 = 1.2$, $b = 0.75$, tokenizer [0-9a-z]+ after case folding, closed-class stopword list. Field weights (S2, S4–S7): act title 3.0, part heading 1.0, section heading 4.0, body 1.0, defined terms 2.0, cross-reference text 0.5.
- Dense: BAAI/bge-base-en-v1.5, cosine similarity, query prefix “Represent this sentence for searching relevant passages:”, windows of 1500 characters with stride 1200, at most 12 windows per section, section score = max over windows.
- Fusion: reciprocal rank fusion with $k = 60$, equal channel weights, candidate depth 100.
- Reranker: cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-6-v2, max length 512, passage = act title, heading and the first 2000 characters of the section.
- Routing (S6, S7): Acts scored by the sum of the top 5 fused section scores; 3 Acts retained; amending Acts folded into their principal enactment.
- Bundle (S7): 15 seeds; expansion over defines, excepts, qualifies, cross_references, procedurally_requires, amends; temporal filter on; graph-support weight $\gamma = 0.15$; seed bonus 0.05.
- Query: normalised background (enriched where enrichment applied) followed by the question. Split seed 13, development fraction 0.17. Bootstrap: 2,000 matter-level resamples, seed 13.

All runs used a single consumer laptop CPU (Windows 11, Python 3.12, PyTorch 2.13 CPU build, no GPU). Wall-clock time over the 40 test queries: BM25 and BM25F under 1 s each, dense retrieval 28 s, hybrid fusion 0.7 s, hybrid with cross-encoder 276 s, Act routing 1.4 s, the bundle retriever 37 s; the ten ablations together 93 s. Corpus embedding with bge-base-en-v1.5 is cached once per corpus fingerprint. Development tuning and smoke runs used the same machine.

E Ablations and recall curves

Removing Act routing raises R@20 (0.518 against 0.480) while lowering C@20 by half a point. Removing the temporal filter raises C@20 to 0.344 because of one question: its gold cites a section of a 2022 amending

Table 3: Ablations of S7 (matter-macro means). No removal changes C@20 by more than one question in 32 matters.

Variant	C@10	C@20	R@20
Full system	0.281	0.312	0.480
without expansion	0.281	0.281	0.452
without act routing	0.297	0.297	0.518
without field weights	0.281	0.312	0.470
without dense	0.281	0.281	0.439
without temporal	0.281	0.344	0.496
without defines	0.281	0.312	0.480
without excepts qualifies	0.281	0.312	0.473
without xref procedural	0.281	0.312	0.475
without amends	0.281	0.281	0.465
without rerank	0.281	0.281	0.454

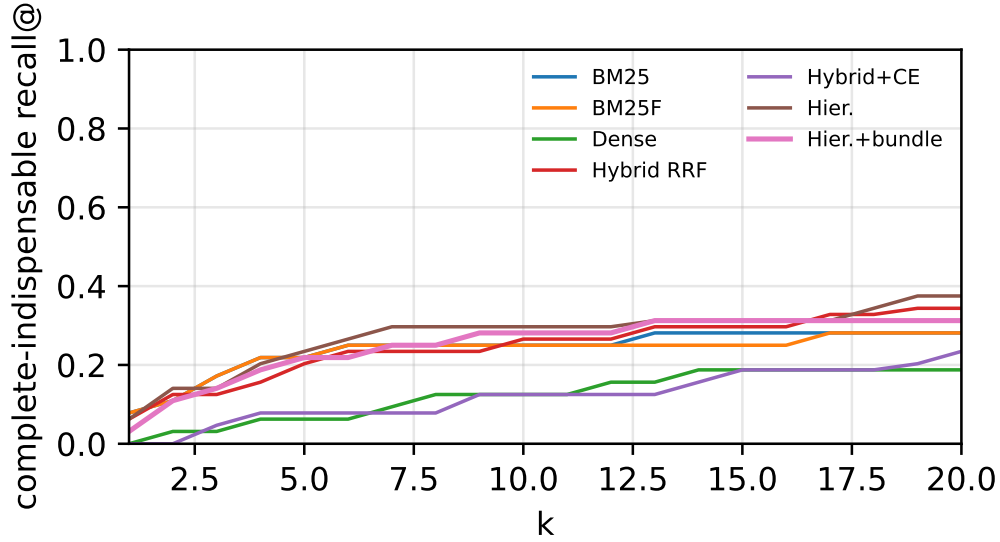


Figure 5: Complete-indispensable recall against the cutoff k on the test split. The curves of the hybrid and hierarchical systems cross repeatedly; none clears 0.4 at $k = 20$.

Act that recites the 2019 wording of a rule the consolidated text no longer carries, so the filter that removes anachronistic law removes the only copy of the applicable text.

F Confidence intervals

System	R@20	C@10	C@20	MRR
BM25	0.49 [0.35, 0.62]	0.25 [0.09, 0.41]	0.28 [0.12, 0.44]	0.50 [0.36, 0.65]
BM25F	0.48 [0.35, 0.61]	0.25 [0.09, 0.41]	0.28 [0.12, 0.44]	0.54 [0.38, 0.70]
Dense	0.38 [0.25, 0.50]	0.12 [0.03, 0.25]	0.19 [0.06, 0.34]	0.32 [0.19, 0.45]
Hybrid RRF	0.55 [0.41, 0.68]	0.27 [0.12, 0.42]	0.34 [0.19, 0.50]	0.54 [0.40, 0.69]
Hybrid + CE	0.41 [0.29, 0.54]	0.12 [0.03, 0.23]	0.23 [0.11, 0.39]	0.22 [0.14, 0.32]
Hierarchical	0.50 [0.34, 0.64]	0.30 [0.16, 0.45]	0.38 [0.22, 0.53]	0.51 [0.35, 0.66]
Hier. + bundle	0.48 [0.34, 0.63]	0.28 [0.12, 0.44]	0.31 [0.16, 0.47]	0.50 [0.36, 0.64]

Paired matter-level bootstrap differences, S7 minus the named system (95% CI), for complete recall at 20 and indispensable recall at 20:

- vs BM25: $\Delta C@20$ +0.031 [-0.062, +0.125], $\Delta R@20$ -0.011 [-0.100, +0.076]

- vs BM25F: $\Delta C@20$ +0.031 [-0.062, +0.125], $\Delta R@20$ -0.002 [-0.092, +0.084]
- vs Dense: $\Delta C@20$ +0.125 [+0.031, +0.250], $\Delta R@20$ +0.101 [-0.018, +0.229]
- vs Hybrid RRF: $\Delta C@20$ -0.031 [-0.156, +0.078], $\Delta R@20$ -0.065 [-0.156, +0.026]
- vs Hybrid + CE: $\Delta C@20$ +0.078 [-0.062, +0.234], $\Delta R@20$ +0.068 [-0.040, +0.187]
- vs Hierarchical: $\Delta C@20$ -0.062 [-0.156, -0.000], $\Delta R@20$ -0.016 [-0.060, +0.021]

G Statutes in the corpus

Table 4 lists every principal enactment in the frozen corpus (fingerprint f119236b806f) with the number of amending Acts the corpus holds for it. The enactments are the 52 statutes named in the Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing course tables, which rank them in three categories; the amending Acts are those whose own text was available as a separate document, so the count reflects source availability, not the full amendment history.

Table 4: Principal enactments in the frozen corpus (52), by year. Cat. is the curriculum category assigned by the Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing course tables (1 most important, 3 important). Sections are the retrieval units the parser produced. Amend. is the number of amending Acts held in the corpus as separate documents whose AMENDS edges point to the enactment (60 in total, of which 9 record no target and are not counted). Fold. is the number of amending instruments already folded into the consolidated text. Edition is the text the section tree was built from.

Enactment	Cat.	Sections	Amend.	Fold.	Edition
Prevention of Frauds Ordinance No. 7 of 1840	1	19	2	5	consolidated
State Lands Encroachments Ordinance No. 12 of 1840	3	10	0	3	consolidated
Definition of Boundaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1844	2	14	0	5	consolidated
Wills Ordinance No. 21 of 1844	1	7	1	5	consolidated
Deeds and Documents (Execution before Public Officers) Ordinance No. 17 of 1852	1	7	0	1	consolidated
Land Surveys Ordinance No. 4 of 1866	3	7	0	1	consolidated
Sannases and Old Deeds Ordinance No. 6 of 1866	3	10	0	1	consolidated
Prescription Ordinance No. 22 of 1871	1	15	1	2	consolidated
Matrimonial Rights and Inheritance Ordinance No. 15 of 1876	1	36	0	1	consolidated
Lands Resumption Ordinance No. 4 of 1887	3	17	0	3	consolidated
Civil Procedure Code No. 2 of 1889	1	798	0	55	consolidated
Surveyors Ordinance No. 15 of 1889	3	20	0	6	consolidated
Powers of Attorney Ordinance No. 4 of 1902	1	17	3	6	consolidated
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907	1	42	5	19	consolidated
Jaffna Matrimonial Rights and Inheritance Ordinance No. 1 of 1911	1	40	0	1	consolidated
Trusts Ordinance No. 9 of 1917	3	123	1	5	consolidated
Kandyan Succession Ordinance No. 23 of 1917	1	4	0	0	consolidated
Registration of Documents Ordinance No. 23 of 1927	1	50	5	15	consolidated
Muslim Intestate Succession Ordinance No. 10 of 1931	1	4	0	0	consolidated
Buddhist Temporalities Ordinance No. 19 of 1931	2	44	1	11	consolidated
Land Settlement Ordinance No. 20 of 1931	3	33	1	4	consolidated
State Land (Claims) Ordinance No. 21 of 1931	3	7	0	0	consolidated
Land Development Ordinance No. 19 of 1935	2	143	0	13	consolidated
Bank of Ceylon Ordinance No. 53 of 1938	3	59	0	13	consolidated
Urban Councils Ordinance No. 61 of 1939	3	263	0	48	consolidated
Land Registers (Reconstructed Folios) Ordinance No. 18 of 1945	2	9	0	1	consolidated
Town and Country Planning Ordinance No. 13 of 1946	3	95	1	5	consolidated
State Lands Ordinance No. 8 of 1947	3	113	0	2	consolidated
Municipal Councils Ordinance No. 29 of 1947	3	349	0	42	consolidated
Registration of Old Deeds and Instruments Ordinance No. 35 of 1947	3	12	0	0	consolidated
Thesawalamai Pre-emption Ordinance No. 59 of 1947	1	14	0	0	consolidated
Mortgage Act No. 6 of 1949	2	126	0	6	consolidated
Land Acquisition Act No. 9 of 1950	2	73	3	7	consolidated
National Housing Act No. 37 of 1954	3	125	1	6	consolidated
Tea and Rubber Estates (Control of Fragmentation) Act No. 2 of 1958	1	29	1	1	as enacted
People's Bank Act No. 29 of 1961	3	63	3	7	consolidated
Local Authorities Housing Act No. 14 of 1964	3	14	1	1	consolidated
Nindagama Lands Act No. 30 of 1968	3	30	0	0	consolidated

Enactment	Cat.	Sections	Amend.	Fold.	Edition
Land Reform Law No. 1 of 1972	2	83	4	5	consolidated
Apartment Ownership Law No. 11 of 1973	1	50	3	4	consolidated
State Mortgage and Investment Bank Law No. 13 of 1975	3	88	3	3	consolidated
Urban Development Authority Law No. 41 of 1978	2	56	0	6	consolidated
National Housing Development Authority Act No. 17 of 1979	3	91	5	5	consolidated
Land Grants (Special Provisions) Act No. 43 of 1979	2	20	0	0	consolidated
Stamp Duty Act No. 43 of 1982	1	75	0	10	consolidated
Western Province Financial Statute No. 6 of 1990	1	108	0	0	consolidated
Registration of Title Act No. 21 of 1998	1	75	0	0	unconfirmed
Survey Act No. 17 of 2002	3	68	0	0	as enacted
Stamp Duty (Special Provisions) Act No. 12 of 2006	1	16	1	1	consolidated
Companies Act No. 7 of 2007	1	534	1	1	consolidated
Land (Restrictions on Alienation) Act No. 38 of 2014	1	26	2	2	consolidated
Revocation of Irrevocable Deeds of Gift on the Ground of Gross Ingratitude Act No. 5 of 2017	1	7	0	0	as enacted